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FEATURES

Understanding H3N2: Symptoms, Transmission, and Prevention

An explainer on the H3N2 influenza virus — its origins in the 1968 Hong Kong pandemic, how it spreads, what symptoms to watch for, and what protection is available as the strain continues to concern health professionals worldwide.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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Have you ever considered how much of an impact your health can have on your life? Your physical health has a significant impact on your overall quality of life, affecting everything from your mood to your level of energy. Tragically, numerous dangers to our well-being can crash our arrangements and leave us feeling powerless. The H3N2 influenza virus, which has been causing health professionals concern in recent years, is one such threat.

What is H3N2 influenza?

In 1968, the H3N2 influenza strain was first observed in Hong Kong. It quickly spread to other nations, including the United States, from there. In September 1968, the first H3N2 influenza outbreak occurred in the United States. It quickly spread across the country, triggering a pandemic that lasted until 1970. Since then, H3N2 has evolved into a seasonal flu virus with global distribution and annual outbreaks. The annual flu vaccine contains the virus, which is still present worldwide.

How did it emerge?

It is believed that genetic reassortment led to the emergence of H3N2 influenza. This happens when two unique seasonal viruses (human flu virus and an avian flu virus for this situation) taint a similar host cell and trade hereditary material, bringing about another virus with an alternate mix of qualities from the original viruses.

How did it spread?

H3N2 influenza spreads worldwide through human-to-human transmission and international travel. India may have been infected with H3N2 influenza due to international travel or an infected person entering the country. The virus can quickly spread from person to person once it is introduced to a population, especially in crowded places like schools, offices, and public transportation. In previous flu seasons, H3N2 influenza was reported in India. It will likely continue to be a seasonal flu virus here.

WHO and The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare in India on H3N2 flu

The World Health Organization (WHO) reported that H3N2 and influenza B viruses were among the most prevalent flu viruses worldwide during the 2019–2020 flu season. The World Health Organization (WHO) and The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare in India intently screen the worldwide flow of flu infections, including H3N2, and give direction and suggestions to nations on influenza counteraction and control techniques.

WHO believes H3N2 flu to be one of the most disturbing influenza subtypes because of its capacity to change quickly and cause extreme sickness, especially in more established grown-ups and small kids. WHO says that everyone should get vaccinated against seasonal flu, including H3N2, every year to avoid getting sick and spreading the virus to other people. In addition to vaccinating people, the WHO encourages people to cover coughs and sneezes, wash their hands frequently, and stay inside when they are ill. WHO also recommends taking antiviral medications to treat severe cases of the flu, including H3N2 influenza.

It is the responsibility of the Indian government to monitor influenza-like illness (ILI) and severe acute respiratory illness (SARI) and to issue periodic reports on the country's flu virus epidemic. When traveling to areas where flu virus outbreaks are known to have occurred, the health ministry advises travelers to take precautions.

What are the symptoms of H3N2 influenza?

H3N2 influenza, also known as the H3N2 flu can cause respiratory disease in people. The symptoms of H3N2 influenza are similar to those of other types of influenza and may include fever, cough, sore throat, runny or stuffy nose, muscle or body aches, headaches, fatigue, vomiting, and diarrhea (more common in children). These symptoms typically begin to manifest one to three days after exposure to the virus and can persist for up to a week or more. H3N2 influenza can sometimes result in more serious complications like pneumonia, especially in young children, the elderly, and people with weak immune systems. It is essential to seek medical attention as soon as you suspect you or a loved one has the flu to receive the necessary treatment and avoid complications.

Who is at a higher risk?

H3N2 influenza can cause death, especially in people who are more likely to get complications. These incorporate small kids, old people, pregnant ladies, and individuals with fundamental ailments like asthma, diabetes, or coronary illness. H3N2 influenza can result in complications like pneumonia, respiratory failure, and even death in severe cases.

How to prevent H3N2 influenza?

Getting vaccinated, washing your hands frequently, avoiding close contact with sick people, covering your mouth and nose, cleaning and disinfecting surfaces, and taking care of your health are all ways to lower your risk of contracting H3N2 influenza. You can help protect yourself and those around you and lower your risk of contracting H3N2 influenza and other illnesses by following these steps.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the H3N2 influenza virus is highly contagious and a significant health risk. Even though outbreaks can be hard to predict and avoid, there are still many things we can do to protect ourselves and our communities. We can lower our chances of getting the virus and spreading it by staying informed, maintaining proper hygiene, and getting vaccinated. It is essential to remember that our health is a valuable resource that necessitates ongoing care as we move forward. We can live happier, healthier lives by making small adjustments to our daily routines and being aware of potential health risks. As a result, let's pledge to prioritize our health and take preventative measures to stop the spread of the H3N2 influenza virus and other infectious diseases. We can create a future that is healthier and more resilient for ourselves and those around us by working together.

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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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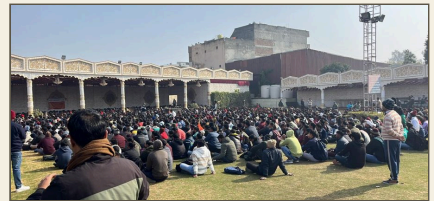
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